

Syllabus Business Projects WT26/27

Instructor

Dr Arne Floh

WU Vienna – Institute for International Business

Senior Lecturer in Marketing

E: arne.floh@wu.ac.at

F: +43-31336-6367

WWW: <https://www.wu.ac.at/en/welthandel/arne-floh/>

Office hours: by appointment

Course Synopsis

Business Projects is a capstone-style course designed for students specializing in International Business. The course centers on the development of a comprehensive international marketing plan, requiring students to apply and integrate the knowledge and skills acquired throughout their studies. Each semester, students work on a project that mirrors real-world challenges faced by companies operating across borders.

At the core of the course are marketing and marketing research. Students are expected to investigate international markets systematically, gathering and interpreting data to evaluate opportunities and risks. This involves identifying customer needs, analyzing competitors, and examining cultural, economic, and regulatory environments. Research findings provide the basis for strategic decision-making and for designing a marketing plan that is both realistic and innovative.

The course emphasizes critical thinking, project management, and teamwork in a multicultural context. Students strengthen their ability to translate theory into practice by combining marketing concepts with evidence-based insights. Collaboration, creativity, and structured analysis are essential elements. By the end of the course, students will deliver a structured international marketing plan and demonstrate the ability to use marketing research as a foundation for strategic recommendations—skills directly transferable to careers in international business.

Learning Objectives

The learning objectives of this course combine analytical, methodological, and practical competencies that are essential for careers in international business and marketing. Students will not only deepen their understanding of marketing concepts and research methods but also gain experience in applying them to complex, real-world contexts. By the end of the course, they will have developed both the technical expertise and the soft skills necessary to operate effectively in global environments. In detail, the learning objectives of the course are as follows:

- Design and present a structured international marketing plan based on systematic analysis and research
- Apply marketing concepts in an international context and evaluate opportunities and risks across markets
- Conduct and interpret marketing research to support evidence-based strategic decision-making
- Analyze competition, customer needs, and cultural influences in global business environments
- Strengthening skills in teamwork, project management, and intercultural collaboration
- Communicate complex ideas clearly and persuasively in both written and oral formats
- Develop creativity and problem-solving abilities to propose innovative and feasible strategies
- Integrate analytical, methodological, and practical competencies relevant to international business and marketing

Teaching and Learning Methods

The course follows a flipped classroom approach designed to foster active learning and critical engagement. Students are expected to prepare before class by conducting independent research on key concepts and methods. Classroom time is then dedicated to discussion, application, and peer feedback, ensuring that theoretical insights are directly connected to the project task. This method emphasizes teamwork, self-directed learning, and the practical application of marketing and research tools in an international business context.

Grading

The assessment strategy for this course is designed to reflect the applied and project-based nature of the learning experience. Students are evaluated through a combination of group work and individual contributions, ensuring that both teamwork and personal development are taken into account.

Over the semester, students will deliver three structured presentations. The first is a **content presentation (15 minutes)** in which students introduce market selection tools, covering their theoretical foundations, real-world applications and pitfalls. This task emphasizes preparation, research, and the ability to explain complex ideas clearly. The second is a **mid-term presentation (20 minutes)**, where teams present the results of their market selection and competitor analysis and demonstrate how marketing research supports their findings. This stage tests students' analytical abilities and their capacity to translate data into meaningful insights. The third is a **final presentation (25 minutes)**, in which students propose a concrete marketing implementation plan, combining market analysis, strategic reasoning, and marketing recommendations. This capstone presentation highlights their ability to design a coherent, evidence-based international marketing plan.

In addition to group work, each student must submit a **one-page self-reflection** on their learning process, focusing on how they applied marketing and research skills in practice. To encourage accountability and fair collaboration, students also complete a **peer review**, evaluating the engagement and contributions of their group members. This multifaceted assessment ensures that students are recognized for both their collective achievements and their individual growth.

Grades are distributed as follows:

- Group presentation 1: Content presentation – market selection tools (20 %)
- Group presentation 2: Market selection and competitor analysis (30 %)
- Group presentation 3: Marketing implementation plan (30 %)
- Self-Reflection (10 %)
- Peer Review (10 %)

The grading scale is as follows:

- 1 (90-100 %)
- 2 (80-89 %)
- 3 (70-79%)
- 4 (51-69%)
- 5 (0-50%)

Specific Task in the winter term 26/27

As part of this course, students will work on a real-world international business case provided by Julius Meinl, the family-owned Viennese coffee roaster founded in 1862 and now run in its fifth generation. Julius Meinl is present in more than 70 countries, mostly through local distribution partners, both in hospitality (cafés, restaurants and hotels, HoReCa) and in grocery retail. As the company has no own sales organisation in most export markets, success depends heavily on the local partner and on how well the brand is positioned in the respective market.

Julius Meinl regards South America as a potential future growth region, where it is currently not present or only marginally. The guiding question is therefore which South American markets are attractive for Julius Meinl, how market entry could look, and how the brand should be marketed. At the heart of the project lies one critical question: several South American countries grow and roast their own coffee and have a strong coffee culture. Why should cafés, hotels, retailers and consumers in such a country choose a coffee brand from Vienna, and who exactly would do so? A convincing market entry and marketing plan must answer this question.

1. Content Presentation: Market Selection Tools

Before analyzing specific markets, each group reviews the tools companies use to screen, compare and select international markets. The presentation covers:

- The theory behind market selection tools (e.g., scoring and weighting models, market attractiveness-competitive strength portfolios, clustering, distance frameworks)
- Real-world applications showing how companies actually use these tools
- Typical pitfalls, such as data availability, subjective weighting or outdated indicators

Each group concludes by recommending the tool it considers most suitable for comparing South American markets for Julius Meinl and applies it in the midterm presentation.

2. Midterm Presentation: Market Selection and Competitor Analysis

Part A: Market selection

All groups compare the same 5 to 6 South American countries, selected together with Julius Meinl, using the same set of criteria, for example:

- Size of the premium coffee segment in hospitality (HoReCa) and retail
- Tourism and international hotel presence
- Purchasing power and economic development
- Competitive landscape
- Import conditions and regulatory environment
- Coffee culture and consumption habits

Groups are expected to:

- Apply the market selection tool(s) chosen in the content presentation in a transparent and replicable way
- Arrive at their own ranking of the countries and justify it
- Explicitly discuss the sensitivity of their ranking to the chosen criteria and weights

Different results between groups are explicitly welcome; there is no single right answer. After this step, each group is assigned one market, ideally a different one per group, so that the results cover several countries.

Part B: Market and competitor analysis

Building on the market selection, each group conducts a structured deep-dive into its assigned country to develop a concrete picture of the coffee market, its competitors and its routes to market. Students should analyze:

- How coffee is consumed out of home and at home
- Which premium coffee brands are already present and at which price levels
- How distribution works in hospitality (HoReCa) and in retail

- Which import conditions and regulations apply
- How key competitors position and communicate their brands

In addition to desk research, students are encouraged to analyze the target city online, for example menus and prices of premium cafés, shelf prices in supermarkets and online shops, online reviews, competitors' social media presence, and which coffee brands hotels offer. This provides a concrete picture of the market and can be carried out entirely from Vienna.

3. Final Presentation: Marketing Implementation Plan

Each group concludes with a market entry and marketing plan for its assigned market. The plan describes not only how the brand is marketed, but also how Julius Meinl enters the market. It covers:

- Target segment and first customers
- Positioning, including an answer to the central question above
- Price positioning relative to the competition
- Distribution via a local partner, including a profile of what a suitable partner would look like
- Communication and in-market activation (including the creative implementation)
- Rough timeline for market entry, KPIs for the first year and the key risks

Data Sources and Framework Conditions

The project is based on publicly available data. Julius Meinl does not provide internal figures such as revenues, margins, prices or partner names, and these are not required. Possible sources include the coffee country reports of the US Department of Agriculture (USDA), trade statistics on coffee imports, national tourism statistics, and publicly available company material from Julius Meinl such as the corporate story, the sustainability report and the website. If students contact companies or individuals for their research, they do so as students working on a university project and not on behalf of Julius Meinl.

Teaching Schedule

Session	Topic	Student Task
1	Course Content & Logistics	Prepare Content Presentation
2	Content Presentation	Country Comparison, Selection Model
3	Coaching Session, Progress Report	Refinement and Revision
4	Coaching Session, Progress Report	Prepare Midterm Presentation
5	Mid-Term Presentation	Assigned Market, Marketing Plan
6	Coaching Session, Progress Report	Refinement and Revision
7	Coaching Session, Progress Report	Prepare Final Presentation
8	Final Presentation	Self-Reflection, Peer Review

Additional Information for Content Presentation

Your first presentation focuses on market selection tools. Working in teams, you will research and summarize the most relevant approaches used to

screen, compare and select international markets (e.g., scoring and weighting models, market attractiveness-competitive strength portfolios, clustering, or distance frameworks). Your task is to cover three aspects: (1) the theory behind the tools, (2) real-world applications showing how companies actually use them, and (3) typical pitfalls such as data availability, subjective weighting, or outdated indicators. Highlight advantages and limitations, and decide which tool you consider most suitable for comparing South American markets for Julius Meinl. Be sure to explain and justify your choice clearly. The presentation should not exceed **15 minutes** and must be limited to **15 slides**. Slides should be **information-rich** and include clear visualizations, charts, or tables wherever possible to support your arguments. All sources used must be documented in detail in a **separate Excel sheet**, which will be submitted alongside your presentation. Your goal is not only to demonstrate knowledge of existing models but also to critically evaluate them and communicate your reasoning in a structured way.

Additional Information for Midterm Presentation

For the midterm presentation, each group is required to submit **one Excel file** and **one presentation file**. The Excel file should contain your country comparison data and all your updated sources including links. Make sure that you select AND apply the appropriate market selection method. The presentation covers both the market selection across the 5 to 6 countries and the market and competitor analysis of your assigned country, and should end with a clear, justified recommendation. The presentation should not exceed 20 minutes.

Final Presentation

The final presentation should last no longer than **25 minutes** and provide a clear summary of both the process and the outcomes of your project. Focus on presenting your marketing implementation plan for Julius Meinl, including a concrete set of communication measures (Do not forget the creative implementation).

The Use of AI

You are explicitly encouraged to use (Generative) AI tools. Please make sure that you tell a rich story when you do your presentations. Be honest and list all tools which you have used. You will be graded on the quality, innovativeness and variety of your sources.

Self-reflection

Students need to write one page answering the following questions: 1) What have you learned? 2) What did you like? And 3) What can be improved? Submissions are made via Canvas until one week after the last session.

Peer Review

Students need to review the engagement and performance of their group mates based on the following form. Submissions are made via Canvas until one week after the last session.

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Peer Rating Form

Each group member is required to submit a peer rating form. This form must contain an evaluation (i.e. a grade) of each group member. Do not assign yourself a grade as this would defeat the idea of peer rating. **The form will be kept in strict confidence.**

In the spaces provided below, please fill in your name, choose your group, and write complete names of all of your group members. Finally, assign a grade on a scale from 0 to 10 to each of your group members (**10 being the highest** and 0 being the lowest grade). Please assign grades based on the following criteria:

- Willingness to carry out assigned tasks
- Ability to meet deadlines
- Quality of the individual's work
- Communication ability and respectful treatment of others
- Availability for and attendance at group meetings
- Following the pre-agreed rules

Your Name:

Your Group:

Group Member Names	Grade
1. Group Member Name	Insert grade
2. Group Member Name	Insert grade
3. Group Member Name	Insert grade
4. Group Member Name	Insert grade
5. Group Member Name	Insert grade

(Optional) Additional Comments